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ROAD TO PARIS LOOKS NICE AND BRIGHT

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After javelin thrower Neeraj Chopra's gold medal in the 2021 Tokyo Olympics and the 2023 World Championships in Budapest, expectations are high as India prepares for this year's Paris Olympics. And now, not just Neeraj but many others are doing well and have raised medal hopes. Our long jumpers are very close to a medal; they are doing well. If they continue doing that without fear, we can win a medal there. They have had enough experience in the last few years, and I think if they go all out, they are capable of medalling at the event.

And our three javelin throwers finished in the top six at the last Worlds, with Neeraj winning gold, so we are expecting something there. Winning two medals is possible in javelin; if one is on top, the other thrower will also get that fearless attitude. They will be supporting each other. Our 4x400m relay men also did exceptionally well at the World Championships, so if they go a little further, they can give a good fight there also.

It's not always a medal; if you are fighting for a medal and if you are in that range, that itself is a great thing for our country. Now, it's not like only one athlete is getting a medal. Every athlete is fighting for a medal, which is a positive sign.

Ranking route: the best road

The qualification standards in some events for Paris



Making the cut: Parul Chaudhary breached the Paris Olympics qualifying standard in the women's 3000m steeplechase finals at the World Athletics Championships in 2023. AFP

are very tough, so only the world-ranking route will help many of our athletes qualify. With this in mind, we have tried to ensure that the main events, the Federation Cup and Inter-State Nationals, do not clash with the Diamond League and other top-level competitions.

If everything works out well, we may have the biggest number of athletes this time. If both (the men's and women's) relay teams make the cut, then the number of athletes in Paris could be around 40.

Doping concern

The road to Paris looks nice and bright, but doping continues to be a big worry.

Certainly, people are taking unwanted substances and performing well in domestic competitions but not doing well in international competitions. Athletes are missing dope tests because they are either not aware of them or are

not too serious about the tests. If they need to change their training location or if they plan to be away for even a day, they must fill out a form. We must emphasise to them that this is a serious matter and that they need to be aware of the procedure. Missing tests is a big issue now.

It's everywhere, not just in athletics. But now that we are on the borderline, we cannot afford any more positive cases.

As told to Stan Rayan